Week 7

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 2 · LESSON 3

Pantheism

BIG IDEA

Pantheism, the main worldview of the East, says god is in everything and is everything, with no line between Creator and creation. Its ideas reach students through karma, meditation, yoga and Star Wars, and losing that line leads straight back to idolatry.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. Pantheism dominates Eastern thought, yet karma, meditation, yoga and Star Wars' "force" show it has reached the West, so students need to learn to recognize it.
2. It teaches that god is literally part of everything, rocks, trees, all of nature, a divine spark or force; that is not the same as the Holy Spirit dwelling in believers.
3. The key word is distinction: naturalism says there is no God, while pantheism says God exists but is not distinct from anything that is created.
4. At the Areopagus, Paul helps Stoics, who believed much like today's pantheists, see that God is personal and near yet distinct from and other than us.
5. Without distinction, rocks and trees are as divine as God, so worshiping them is no different; losing it leads back to the root of sin, idolatry.
6. Teach this in love, never mocking other worldviews; a God who is distinct, holy and other than us gives a standard for right and wrong, just and unjust.

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. Where might you treat creation, a person or yourself as something close to divine, even in small ways?
2. How does God being completely other than you shape the way you decide what is right and wrong?
3. Could a skeptical student hear you describe another worldview without feeling mocked? What would help?

ASK YOUR GROUP

In small group: questions to ask your students.

1. In your own words, what does pantheism say about God, and how is that different from the Holy Spirit living in a believer?
2. Where have you seen ideas like karma, "the force" or a divine spark in movies, music or wellness trends?
3. Why does it matter whether God is distinct from creation? What changes if he isn't?
4. What things get treated as if they were divine in our culture, and what does that look like at your school?
5. How could you talk with a friend who holds another worldview so they feel respected, not made fun of?

Summary and transcript of the Week 7 Leader Video, for this church's Awana® leaders: internal ministry use only, not for redistribution. Awana® and Journey: Advocates® and the Journey mark are trademarks of Awana Clubs International, used here by a member church; this handout is not affiliated with or endorsed by Awana. The transcript is of the Leader Video, lightly edited for reading.

WEEK 7 · LEADER VIDEO

The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Why pantheism matters

0:05 If naturalism is the dominant view of the West, pantheism is the dominant view of the East. Pantheism is interesting, and it may seem like much of pantheistic thought is far from your students. Even though it largely dominates Eastern culture, from Hindus to Buddhists and a bunch of others in that part of the world, it has made its way to the West — and in a really strange way. So you might think, for your youth group: why are we talking about pantheism? Why are we bothering with this? That's another part of the world, and I'm not taking my kids on a mission trip over there, so do I really need to spend an entire week dedicated to this sort of Eastern thought?

1:00 Well, do you like Star Wars? Have you ever heard of karma, meditation, even yoga? All of these things come from pantheistic thought, or a pantheistic worldview. So naturally, we cannot ignore its influence. We have to address it, we have to discuss it, and we have to get our students to understand what it exactly is, so that they can identify it and navigate through it successfully.

What pantheism teaches

1:27 So what is pantheism? What are we talking about? Essentially, think of it this way: the idea of God — and I'm going to write God with a small g — is in all. Now, you can even say, more specifically, God is all. In Christianity we talk about the idea of the Holy Spirit being within us, right? So God is in us, and that's sort of the idea. Jesus comes, Jesus goes, He sends the Spirit, and the Spirit dwells within us. We have this idea of God in us — not just God with us, but God in us. Okay, that's great, but that's not the same thing when we're talking about pantheism. We're talking about the idea that God is literally part of everything.

2:08 So in a pantheistic way, God would be in me just as much as in the camera that I'm speaking to, as this table, as this Bible, as this marker, as this whiteboard, rocks, trees — pretty much all of it. All of nature is part of the divine. It's all part of who God is. It's all part of this divine sort of idea of the universe that's all combined into one. There's a divine spark in everything. That's essentially what pantheism teaches. So that's where we get this idea of essence, or force. When we talk about Star Wars, the idea of "may the force be with you" — that's the same kind of idea. It's a divine essence that's part of this. We can call it a force. There's something going on behind the scenes in everything else.

The key idea of distinction

3:08 So God is present everywhere. It defines life now, it defines life later, it defines relationships, it defines everything — how we see and relate to God. But the key I want you to get here is the idea of distinction, and this is going to be important as you move forward. If naturalism is

saying there's no God at all, pantheism is saying, well, there is God, but God is not distinct from anything that's created. God is a part of creation, He's a part of you and me; there's just no distinction. There's no God and us. There's just everything all together. So for pantheism, there is no distinction at all. Keep that in the back of your mind, especially as we move to next week when we talk about monotheism. That's going to be really, really important.

Paul at the Areopagus

3:59 In our Bible study portion, we talk about Paul. We talk about Paul's interaction at the Areopagus on Mars Hill, and we talk about his interaction between the Epicureans and the Stoics. What's interesting is that these Stoics actually believed much of the same kinds of things that modern-day pantheism believes — that idea that God is somehow packed into every little piece of our world. And what Paul does is help them see that there is a distinction between the two: that God is here and we are here. That there's a separation. That although He's personal, although He's right here with us, He's distinct and other than us. And that's incredibly important.

4:53 Because what this does — the loss of distinction — is actually what leads us to the root of all sin, right? Of creating God, or creating idols that are a substitute for God. If you say that there's no distinction, then all of these things are just as divine as God. So I can worship rocks and trees and everything else. It's not any different if we don't have some kind of distinction. So it drives us right back to the root of our sin. It drives us right back to idolatry.

Pantheism in Western culture

5:25 Your students probably won't see it right away, but you need to help them begin to see how Western culture has actually embraced a lot of pantheistic ideas about God and creation. Again, let's go back to the buffet. It's super easy for us to say, "Wow, that sounds really cool," because I can see how beautiful creation is and want to make that into a God-like thing. Or I can treat somebody, or an activity, that way — or I can find a center in myself and be that kind of person and elevate myself to a God-like stature. That sounds really cool.

6:05 And along the buffet line, it sounds like I can say, well, if I care about people, I can elevate them to that same status too. So I like justice; that seems to speak to some of my morality. Again, you start to go back to that buffet and start to piece things together. But when we put them all together, we realize once again that this isn't coherent and it isn't consistent.

Speak truth in love

6:30 Now, one quick word of note here that I want to make sure we're clear on. If you're doing everything really, really well, chances are you have some students who are either seeking or maybe skeptical, who have some questions and are curious. And as we're talking about other worldviews — whether they believe these things specifically or not — you want to be careful that we don't offend. We want to be careful that we speak truth, that we do so in love, but that we help them understand that these things are terribly inconsistent and they don't work.

7:12 But we need to do it without making fun of it. We need to do it without making light of it. Because when we're talking about worldviews, as we talked about a few weeks ago, these things are ingrained in us and they are embedded in us, and to change is a huge, monumental change, and it can often, like we said, create some anxiety. So the last thing we want to do is invite non-believing students, invite our seekers and our skeptics, into our youth space and say, "Come with your questions, come with your curiosity, and we'll help you navigate — and we're going to accept you," but at the same time make light of or make fun of other worldviews. That's not going to work.

7:55 This is a very popular worldview. So is naturalism. There are some really, really smart people who have said some really, really intelligent things about these worldviews. Now, that doesn't make them true, but we have to respect what they believe and speak to how it does not line up with reality and how it does not line up with truth — but do so in love.

Remember this

8:15 So remember: pantheism says God is all. God is in everything and a part of everything — the rocks, the trees, everything — and it's a divine force. And essentially, the key word here is that there is no distinction between God and creation, between creator and creation. Not only does this lead to the idea of idolatry — if we don't have the distinction, what does that make God? The very fact that we call Him God means that He is completely distinct, completely other than us, and completely holy.

8:52 And the idea is this: if God is here and completely other than me, then I have a standard to look to, so I understand what's right and what's wrong. I understand what's just and unjust. I understand the idea of love versus hate. Putting God outside of myself and making God completely distinct helps us navigate reality in a way that makes sense. We have to have some kind of distinction. It's God who is other than, God who is holy, God who is supreme creator over all. And it's in Him that we live and move and have our being.